



THE APERTURE METHOD™ · CLASSROOM PROGRAM

Business Cards

Six businesses, six different problems

*The question this answers: **What is actually holding this business back?***

PREPARED FOR

Grades 8–12

The Woodlands, Texas

Set of Six · Edition One · The Aperture Method™

A NOTE ON THE BUSINESSES: Every business in this packet is invented. The streets, parks and shopping centers are real places in The Woodlands, Texas, so the exercise feels like home, but no real business is described, and no real numbers are used.

HOW TO USE THESE

Six businesses

One card per team. Everything a team needs to find the answer is printed on the card. There is no missing information and no trick.

Each business has exactly one thing holding it back, and each of the six is held back by something different. Print single-sided, one business per page. Cardstock if the copier will take it.

#	Business	Where	What is really wrong (facilitator only)
1	Waterway Waffle Co.	walk-up window on The Woodlands Waterway, a two-minute walk from Town Green Park	THE THING
2	Creekside Cuts	barbershop in a shopping center at Creekside Park Village Green	WHO
3	Panther Creek Lawn Crew	yards around Panther Creek and Cochran's Crossing	MONEY
4	Alden Bridge Bakehouse	bakery in a strip center off Research Forest Drive, in the Village of Alden Bridge	WHO DOES THE WORK
5	Town Green Smoothie Bar	small shop steps from Town Green Park, in sight of the Cynthia Woods Mitchell Pavilion	WHERE & WHEN
6	Kickback Sneakers	resale shop on the SECOND floor of a building off Six Pines Drive, above a nail salon. No sign at street level.	WHO

Do not hand out this page

The table above names the answer. Print pages 2 onward for students.

BUSINESS 1 OF 6

Waterway Waffle Co.

WHERE A walk-up window on The Woodlands Waterway, a two-minute walk from Town Green Park

WHAT Belgian waffles, coffee and fresh orange juice. Open every day, 7:00am to 2:00pm.

What we know

- A waffle sells for \$8. The batter, butter and toppings cost \$2.
- They own ONE waffle iron. One waffle takes 4 minutes to cook.
- Two people work the window: one takes orders, one cooks.
- The rush is Saturday and Sunday, 8:00am to 10:00am. The line goes out to the sidewalk.
- Last Saturday they sold 90 waffles.
- Last Saturday the person taking orders counted 40 people who stood in line, waited, and then left without buying anything.
- Rent, wages, power and supplies come to \$1,900 a week.
- Their reviews are 4.7 stars. People love the waffles.

Your job

Look at this business through all five lenses: WHO · MONEY · THE THING · WHO DOES THE WORK · WHERE & WHEN.

Name ONE thing that is holding it back. Not three. One.

Point to the fact on this card that proves it. Then say what you would do about it, and what it would be worth.

BUSINESS 2 OF 6

Creekside Cuts

WHERE A barbershop in a shopping center at Creekside Park Village Green

WHAT Haircuts, fades and beard trims. Four barbers. Open Tuesday through Saturday.

What we know

- A haircut is \$30.
- Last year, 2,400 different people got a haircut here.
- Of those 2,400 people, 1,560 came exactly one time and never came back.
- The other 840 came back again and again, an average of 6 times over the year.
- The shop spends \$900 a month on ads to bring in new people.
- Reviews average 4.6 stars. The barbers are good and everyone says so.
- Nobody at the shop has ever called, texted or emailed a customer after their haircut.

Your job

Look at this business through all five lenses: WHO · MONEY · THE THING · WHO DOES THE WORK · WHERE & WHEN.

Name ONE thing that is holding it back. Not three. One.

Point to the fact on this card that proves it. Then say what you would do about it, and what it would be worth.

BUSINESS 3 OF 6

Panther Creek Lawn Crew

WHERE Mowing yards around Panther Creek and Cochran's Crossing

WHAT Two high-school seniors, Dev and Ray, mow lawns on Saturdays. They pay a friend to help.

What we know

- They charge \$35 a yard. They have charged \$35 since the day they started, two years ago.
- Each yard takes about 45 minutes with three people working.
- Costs per yard: gas for the mowers \$4, gas for the truck \$3, blades and wear \$2. That is \$9 a yard.
- They pay their friend Marcus \$15 an hour, and he is with them the whole route.
- They do 8 yards on a Saturday, working 8:00am to 4:00pm, eight hours, including driving between houses.
- Every single customer has said yes. Nobody has ever said the price was too high.
- They have a waiting list of 5 more houses they do not have time for.

Your job

Look at this business through all five lenses: WHO · MONEY · THE THING · WHO DOES THE WORK · WHERE & WHEN.

Name ONE thing that is holding it back. Not three. One.

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BUSINESS 4 OF 6

Alden Bridge Bakehouse

WHERE A bakery in a strip center off Research Forest Drive, in the Village of Alden Bridge

WHAT Coffee and pastries for walk-ins, plus custom decorated cakes ordered ahead.

What we know

- A pastry sells for \$4 and costs \$1.20 to make.
- A custom cake sells for \$95, costs \$22 in ingredients, and takes 3 hours to decorate.
- Maria, the owner, is the ONLY person in the building who can decorate a cake.
- Maria also works the register, orders the supplies, does the schedule and locks up at night.
- Three other employees can bake, clean and run the register. None of them has ever been taught to decorate.
- Last month the shop turned down 14 cake orders. The reason written on every one: "Maria didn't have time."
- There is no waiting list problem for pastries. They never run out.

Your job

Look at this business through all five lenses: WHO · MONEY · THE THING · WHO DOES THE WORK · WHERE & WHEN.

Name ONE thing that is holding it back. Not three. One.

Point to the fact on this card that proves it. Then say what you would do about it, and what it would be worth.

BUSINESS 5 OF 6

Town Green Smoothie Bar

WHERE A small shop steps from Town Green Park, in sight of the Cynthia Woods Mitchell Pavilion

WHAT Smoothies, açai bowls and iced coffee.

What we know

- A smoothie sells for \$9. The fruit, milk and cup cost \$2.70.
- They are open Monday through Friday, 9:00am to 5:00pm. Closed Saturday and Sunday. Closed every evening.
- A normal weekday brings in about \$340.
- The Pavilion next door hosts more than 60 concerts a year, mostly Friday and Saturday nights.
- An average concert draws about 12,000 people, and most of them walk past this shop to get there.
- On concert nights, this shop is dark and locked.
- A hiring sign has been in the window for two months. They have not called anyone back.

Your job

Look at this business through all five lenses: WHO · MONEY · THE THING · WHO DOES THE WORK · WHERE & WHEN.

Name ONE thing that is holding it back. Not three. One.

Point to the fact on this card that proves it. Then say what you would do about it, and what it would be worth.

BUSINESS 6 OF 6

Kickback Sneakers

WHERE A resale shop on the SECOND floor of a building off Six Pines Drive, above a nail salon. No sign at street level.

WHAT Buys, sells and trades used and rare sneakers.

What we know

- A pair sells for about \$120. They pay about \$70 for it. That is \$50 profit a pair.
- They sell 45 pairs a month.
- Reviews: 4.9 stars from 61 people. Customers describe the owner as the person who knows more about sneakers than anyone in Montgomery County.
- The shop has NO Instagram account, NO TikTok, and no posts anywhere. Not one.
- When asked how they found the shop, customers said: 70% "a friend told me," 25% "I saw the sign upstairs," 5% "Google."
- More than 7,000 high-school students live within four miles of the door.
- Nothing is wrong with the prices, the product, the staff or the hours.

Your job

Look at this business through all five lenses: WHO · MONEY · THE THING · WHO DOES THE WORK · WHERE & WHEN.

Name ONE thing that is holding it back. Not three. One.

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